

# Microsoft 365 Copilot Analytics

## Data Strategy

Entra ID vs. Org Data Upload — What to connect, why, and how to decide

| Document Property | Value                             |
|-------------------|-----------------------------------|
| Section           | Strategy                          |
| Audience          | Solution Architect, IT Admin, CIO |
| Version           | 4.0                               |
| Published         | April 2026                        |

### How This Document Fits

This is a **Strategy** guide. Read this to decide your data approach. Then hand off to IT with the Data Onboarding Guide for step-by-step implementation.

## 1. Why Upload Org Data? (Entra ID vs. Org Data Upload)

A common question: *"We already have Department, Manager, and Organisation in Entra ID — why do we need to upload a CSV?"*

Entra ID provides a baseline, but org data uploads unlock significantly more analytics capability:

| Capability                                          | Entra ID Only                                                 |
|-----------------------------------------------------|---------------------------------------------------------------|
| Department filter on dashboard                      | Yes (Entra ID “Department” attribute)                         |
| Job Function / Job Discipline filter                | No                                                            |
| Location filter                                     | No                                                            |
| Level / Seniority filter                            | No                                                            |
| Custom attributes (Cost Centre, Agency, BU, Region) | No                                                            |
| Multi-agency / multi-BU partitioning                | Yes — if each agency has a distinct email domain, use the sys |
| Before/after cohort segmentation in Power BI        | No segmentation                                               |
| Manager hierarchy accuracy                          | Depends on Entra ID completeness                              |
| Data freshness control                              | Updated by directory team (often delayed)                     |

**TIP: When Entra ID Alone Is Sufficient**

If you **only** need the Copilot Dashboard with tenant-level views and Department filtering — and the Entra ID Department attribute is accurate and consistently populated — you can skip the org data upload. However, if you need **any** of the following, org data upload is required: Location or Job Function filters, custom attributes (Cost Centre, Agency), or before/after cohort analysis in Power BI.

## 2. What Breaks with an Incomplete Entra ID Hierarchy?

If the Entra ID `Manager` attribute is missing or inconsistent for many users:

| Feature                                       | Impact                                                                        |
|-----------------------------------------------|-------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Auto CxO Identification                       | Fewer leaders are auto-identified. Users without a clear reporting line       |
| Manager Settings (team-level data)            | Managers without a populated <code>Manager</code> attribute or without enough |
| Filter by manager hierarchy (Publish Reports) | Published reports with "Filter by manager hierarchy" will show incom          |
| Advanced Analytics cohort segmentation        | Manager-based grouping will be inaccurate.                                    |

**Recommendation:** If more than 20% of users lack a Manager attribute, prioritise fixing directory data or supplement with an org data CSV upload that includes correct `ManagerId` values.

### 3. The Data Source Change Warning

---

Once org data is uploaded, it **replaces Entra ID as the data source** for the uploaded attributes in dashboard filters:

- Department values come from the CSV, not from Entra ID — even if they differ
- If you stop uploading, the data becomes stale (not reverted to Entra ID)
- **Reversal is now self-service:** You can use **parallel data ingestion** to keep Entra as the source for `ManagerId` and `Organization` while adding custom attributes via CSV. To stop using uploaded data entirely, clear the Entra connection selections or use the “Replace All data” option with a single dummy row. See Microsoft Learn.
- **Before uploading:** Confirm readiness to own the ongoing refresh cycle (monthly re-uploads recommended)

## 4. Choose Your Upload Method

Start with *"What HRIS do you use?"* — not *"how do I upload a CSV."*

| Method                         | Who Manages                   | Status                | Best For         |
|--------------------------------|-------------------------------|-----------------------|------------------|
| SAP SuccessFactors Connector   | Global Admin + SAP SF Admin   | GA                    | Organisations u  |
| Workday Connector              | Global Admin + Workday Admin  | GA                    | Organisations u  |
| Azure Blob Storage             | Global Admin + Data Engineer  | GA                    | Automated CSV    |
| API-Based Import               | Global Admin + Developer      | Preview               | Programmatic p   |
| CSV Upload — M365 Admin Center | Org Data Source Administrator | GA                    | Universal fallba |
| CSV Upload — Viva Insights     | Insights Administrator        | Deprecated (mid-2026) | Legacy path. U   |

**NOTE: Decision Logic**

- **Use SAP SuccessFactors or Workday** if your org runs either HRIS — eliminates manual CSV entirely
- **Use Azure Blob Storage** if you want automated CSV drops from a data warehouse
- **Use API-based import** if you need incremental refresh or have a custom HRIS
- **Use CSV upload** for everything else — universal compatibility

**TIP: Bypass On-Premises AD**

If your HRIS data flows through **SAP SuccessFactors → middleware → on-premises AD → Entra ID**, be aware that Viva Insights only picks up 3 attributes from Entra (PersonId, ManagerId, Organization). Custom fields in Entra `extensionAttributes` are **not synced**.

**Solution:** Use the HRIS connector to send data directly to M365 — bypassing AD entirely for analytics purposes.

# 5. Data Planning Worksheet

Complete this before any upload. Share answers with your IT team when you hand off to the Data Onboarding Guide.

| # | Question                                                                                                          |
|---|-------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| 1 | Which HRIS does your organisation use? (SAP SF, Workday, Oracle, Custom, None)                                    |
| 2 | Can your HRIS export a CSV with employee email, manager email, and department?                                    |
| 3 | Which dashboard filters do you need beyond Department? (Job Function, Location, Level, Cost Centre, Agency, F     |
| 4 | Do you need custom attributes for segmentation in Power BI reports? (e.g., Copilot Pilot Group, Hire Date, BU)    |
| 5 | Who will own the monthly data refresh? (HR, IT, Data Engineering)                                                 |
| 6 | Is your tenant migrated to "Organizational Data in Microsoft 365" in M365 Admin Center?                           |
| 7 | Do multiple agencies share a single email domain? (If yes, you'll need a custom Agency attribute for partitioning |
| 8 | Do you need to share org data with apps beyond Viva Insights? (M365 Profile, People Skills)                       |

## 6. Organizational Data Upload Migration

---

### IMPORTANT: April 2026 Migration

Microsoft is migrating all tenants from the Viva Insights web app to the **M365 Admin Center** as the single upload point. By mid-2026, all tenants will be migrated.

- New platform: **Organizational Data in Microsoft 365** at `admin.microsoft.com` → Setup → Migration and imports
- New role: **Organizational Data Source Administrator** manages uploads
- Supports HRIS connectors, Azure Blob, API-based import — not just CSV
- Data serves multiple M365 apps (Copilot Dashboard, Viva Insights, M365 User Profile)

### Which path am I on?

1. Go to `admin.microsoft.com` → Setup → Migration and imports
2. If you see "**Organizational Data in Microsoft 365**" → you're migrated → follow the M365 Admin Center path in the Data Onboarding Guide
3. If you don't see it → you're pre-migration → follow the Viva Insights legacy path
4. If unsure → check Message Center for migration notifications

# 7. What to Read Next

| Ready to...                            | Read this                                    |
|----------------------------------------|----------------------------------------------|
| Upload data (step-by-step)             | Data Onboarding Guide (Setup layer)          |
| See the full attribute mapping table   | Attribute Reference (Reference layer)        |
| Troubleshoot a failed upload           | Troubleshooting Guide (Reference layer)      |
| Understand multi-agency data isolation | Multi-Agency Decision Guide (Strategy layer) |

## Disclaimer

This guide is provided as a procedural reference. Always refer to Organizational Data in Microsoft 365 on Microsoft Learn for the most up-to-date information.